Well, come 2024 and it is time to be glum. During the past ten years, humanity has taken an alarming number of steps towards the gates of hell. The Russian invasion of Ukraine and rising tensions between the USA and China suddenly make a Third World War a realistic possibility. Of course, history will continue to surprise us in coming years, and hopefully humanity will make wiser decisions and move away from the brink. In 2014 I also noted that the future is unknown, and that "what seems to be just around the corner may never materialize" while "other unimagined scenarios will in fact come to pass."

But perhaps the most important thing that has happened since 2014 is the revolution in artificial intelligence (AI). When writing *Sapiens* I made a few passing references to AI, but hardly considered it a subject of much interest. When in 2016 I published my next book, *Homo Deus*, AI suddenly took centre stage. Writing about the distant future of humanity, I worried that AI might eventually do to *Homo sapiens* what we have done to the other animals. *Homo Deus* ended by questioning, "What will happen to society, politics and daily life when nonconscious but highly intelligent algorithms know us better than we know ourselves?" The book warned that as AI gains in power, we Sapiens "might be reduced from engineers to chips, then to data, and eventually we might dissolve within the torrent of data like a clump of earth within a gushing river."

When writing *Homo Deus*, I thought I was issuing a warning about developments that might happen centuries from now, or at least a few decades in the future. By 2024, the future has arrived. Highly intelligent algorithms already get to know us better than we know ourselves, and we are floundering in the data torrent that threatens to dissolve our societies.

AI is still in its infancy, but even the baby AI of 2024 is fundamentally different from any previous invention in human history. Stone knives and atom bombs made humans powerful, because the power to decide how to use the knife or the bomb always remained in human hands. A flint blade couldn't decide by itself whether it would be used to murder someone or extract a thorn, and a nuclear missile couldn't decide by itself whom to bomb. In contrast, AI is the first tool that can make decisions by itself, and it therefore threatens to take power away from us.

AI is also the first tool that can create new ideas, and even invent entire new stories by itself. In *Sapiens* I emphasised the key role of stories in history. The ability to invent stories has been the superpower that has